Bed Among the Lentils

By Alan Bennett

Recommend British accent . . .

I stand up and say, 'My name is Susan. I am a vicar's wife and I am an alcoholic'. Then I tell my story. Or some of it anyway. 'Don't pull any punches', says Clem, my counselor. 'Nobody's going to be shocked, believe me, love, we've all been there.' But I don't tell them about Mr. Ramesh because they've not been there. 'Listen, people. I was so drunk I used to go and sleep with an Asian grocer. Yes, and you won't believe this. I loved it. Loved every minute'. Dear oh dear. This was a real drunken lady.

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INTRODUCTION

Life for Susan, wife of Geoffrey the vicar, is complicated. She is always expected to be on parade. Why? Actor's wives don't come to every performance; a barrister's wife isn't always in court – why should she be expected to be present at every service? It's very stressful, especially if you are hopeless with the church flowers, can't run a tight rummage sale, and you're an awful cook! She has to find ways of dealing with the stress. Bed Among the Lentils by Alan Bennett

Geoffrey's bad enough but I'm glad I wasn't married to Jesus. The lesson this morning was the business in the Garden of Gethsemane when Jesus prays and the disciples keeps falling asleep. He wakes them up and say, "Could you not watch with me one hour?" It's my mother.

The sermon was about sex. I didn't actually nod off, though I have heard it before. Marriage gives the OK to sex is the gist of it, but while it is far from being the be all and end all sex is nevertheless the supreme joy of the married state and a symbol of the

relationship between us and God. SO, Geoffrey concludes, when we put our money in the plate it is a symbol of everything in our lives we are offering to God and that includes our sex. I could only find 10 pence.

Amazing scenes at the church door. Geoffrey stands there the wind billowing out his surplice and ruffling his hair, what "Who's Who in the Diocese of Ripon' calls 'his schoolboy good looks'. I helped put away the books while he did his 'underneath this cassock I am but a man like everybody else' act. Mrs. Shrubsole burble, 'We must cherish him'.

We came back and I cherished him with some chicken wings in a tuna fish sauce.

GREGORY: 'That went down well'.

SUSAN: 'The chicken wings?'

GREGORY: 'My sermon. I felt it hit the nail on the head'.

He put his hand over mine, hoping, I suppose, that having hit one nail he might hit another, but I said I had to go round with the parish magazine. Geoffrey was off to Evensong, was I going to come?

One of the unsolved mysteries of life, or the unsolved mysteries of my life, is why the vicar's wife is expected to go to church at all. A barrister's wife doesn't have to go to court, an actor's wife isn't at every performance so why have I always got to be on parade? Not to mention the larger question of whether one believes in God. To look at me, the hair, the flat chest, the wan smile, you'd think I was just cut out for God. And maybe I am. I'd just like to be asked that's all. It could be that Geoffrey doesn't believe in God either. I've always longed to ask him only God never seems to crop up. 'Geoffrey do you really believe in God? I mean, God's just a job like any other. You've got to bring home the bacon somehow'. But no. Not a word. The subject's never discussed.

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After he'd gone, I discovered we were out of sherry so I drive into Leeds. There's a little Indian shop behind the Infirmary I've found--it sells drinks and anything really, the way they do. Open last thing at night, Sundays included, my ideal. Ramesh he's called, Mr. Ramesh, whose first name turns out also to be Ramesh. Ramesh Ramesh. --Though Ramesh may be his Christian name. Only not Christian of course. I've been twice now, only this time he sits me in the back place on a sack of something and talks. He's married apparently, but his wife's only fourteen so they won't let her in. Little statuette of God on the wall. A god, not The God. One of several thousand apparently. "Safety in numbers', I said but he didn't understand. He calls me Mrs. Vicar. He has lovely teeth.

Once upon a time I had my life planned out…I was all set out to turn into a wonderful woman… equipped with the skills necessary: how to produce jam, how to whip Victoria sponge, how to plan and carry a successful garden fete. But I can do none of these things. I'm even a fool at the flower arrangement.

On this particular morning, I'm paired with Mrs. Shrubsole to do the altar and the lectern. My honest opinion, never voiced needless to say, is that if they were really sincere about religion they'd forget flower arrangement altogether and put the money towards the current most popular famine. However, I wander over with a few dog-eared chrysanthemums. They look as if they could do with an immediate drink so I call in at the vestry and root out a vase or two from the cupboard where Geoffrey keeps the communion wine. I assume I am doing the alter and Mrs. Shrubsole the lectern, but when I wonder out of the vestry Mrs. S is at the altar well embarked on her arrangement. She smiled sweetly, 'Do you have a preference'? The only preference I have is to shove my chrysanthemums up her nose but instead I practice a bit of Christian forbearance and retire to the vestry for a bit to calm my shattered nerves, and when I come out, Mrs.

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Shrubsole has apparently finished. So I wander up and take a look, 'Mrs. Shrubsole. This is not a floral arrangement. This is a booby trap! Permit me to demonstrate'. And I begin getting down on my knees, only I must have slipped because next thing I know I'm rolling down the altar steps and end up banging my head on the communion rail.

When I woke up I got the car out and drove to Leeds. I sat in the shop a bit, not saying much. Then I felt a bit wanny and Mr. Ramesh let me go into the back place to lie down. I must have dozed off because when I woke up Mr. Ramesh has come in and started taking off his clothes.

SUSAN: 'What are you doing?'

RAMESH: 'I have closed the shop.'

SUSAN: 'It's only nine. You don't close till eleven'.

RAMESH: 'I do tonight--a chance in a million, a turn up for the books. Will you take your clothes off please?'

And I did.

We made love there among the lentils on the second Sunday after Trinity.

'So how did you come to AA'? they ask. 'My husband', I say. 'The vicar. He persuaded me'. But I lie. It was not my husband, it was Mr. Ramesh, the Mr. Ramesh who one Sunday night turned his troubled face towards me with its struggling moustache and asked if he might take the bull by the horns and inquire if intoxication was a prerequisite for sexual intercourse, or whether it was only when I was going to bed with him, the beautiful Mr. Ramesh, twenty six, with wonderful legs, whether it was only with him I had to be inebriated. And was it, asked his slim, flawless and troubled creature, was it perhaps his color? Because if not he would like to float the suggestion that sober is even nicer. So the credit for the road to Damascus goes to Mr. Ramesh.

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So now everything has changed. For the moment I am a new woman and Geoffrey is a new man. And he brings it up on the slightest pretext. 'My wife's and alcoholic, you know. Yes. It's a great challenge to me and to the parish as extended family'. From being a fly in the ointment I find myself transformed into a feather in his cap. Included it in his sermon on Prayers Answered when he reveals that he and the fan club have been having these jolly get togethers in which they'd all prayed over what he calls 'my problem'. We were at some doleful diocesan jamboree last week and I'm stuck there clutching my grapefruit juice as Geoffrey's telling the tale to some bearded cleric. Suddenly he seizes my hand. 'We met it with love', he cries, as if love were some all-purpose antibiotic, which to Geoffrey it probably is.

I've caught the other young, upwardly mobile parsons sneaking looks at me now and again and you see them thinking why weren't they smart enough to marry an alcoholic, problem wives whom they could do a nice redemption job on, right there on their own doorstep. Because there's no stopping Geoffrey now. He grips my hand in public, nay *brandishes* it. 'We're a team', he cries. Looks certain to be rural dean and that's only the beginning. As the bishop says, 'Just the kind of man we're looking for on the bench… someone with a seasoned compassion, someone who's looked life in the face. Someone who's been there'.

Mr. Ramesh sold his shop. He's gone back to India to fetch his wife. She's old enough now apparently. I went down there on Sunday. There was a boy writing Under New Management on the window. Spelled wrong. And something underneath in Hindi, spelled right probably. He said he thought Mr. Ramesh would be getting another shop, only in Preston.
They do that of course, Asians, build something up, get it going nicely, then take the profit and move on. It's a good thing. We ought to be more like that, more enterprising.

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My group meets twice a week and I go. Religiously. And that's what it is, of course. I never liked going to one church so I end up going to two. Geoffrey would call that the wonderful mystery of God. I call it bad taste. And I wouldn't do it to a dog. But that's the thing nobody ever says about God… he has no taste at all.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Alan Bennett
ISBN: 978-0573132247
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Feb 1998

AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier - DI

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